The Display of Your Choice

Given the wide range of monitors available in different sizes, what exactly should you go in for? 15-inch monitors are still considered the primary choice for all new systems for both the home and the office because of the price factor. These monitors cost around Rs 4,000 less than a 17-inch monitor, so unless you really need a bigger viewing area, it doesn't make much sense going in for a 17-inch monitor. However, just like the 15-inch eased out the 14-inch, in the coming years, the 17-inch might replace the 15-inch as the standard. For people who need to do basic image-editing work or those who can afford the price, a 17-inch monitor will offer a better viewing experience as also better resolution and quality.

The 19-inch category as of now, is way too expensive. However, given its viewable area, it's the perfect choice for the professional and medium to large DTP setups. The 18-inch viewable area that you get is almost perfect for the professional designer or those working on CAD/CAM workstations.

The 21-inch monitor provides for unmatched screen size and resolution and is more suited for people like interior designers or architects who have to deal with big designs and drawings. The screen size eliminates the need for scrolling in most of the cases. But remember that 21-inch screens are quite expensive, starting off at around Rs 45,000 (roughly the cost of a new, assembled system).

one-fourth, one-third, half and full resolution with a solid reference band. Here, we observed the full resolution band and saw whether there were any gaps visible between the two bars. The vertical bar resolution test does the same with the bars being placed vertically.

Among the 15-inch monitors the one that did quite well in these two tests was the Compaq MV540. It clearly showed gaps between the bar, but a slight moiré pattern was visible. The moiré pattern occurs when two identical dots overlap each other and the alignment is not perfect. The line (dark and light) pattern that appears is called the moiré pattern. If the electron beam doesn't perfectly match the dot on the shadow mask then the moiré pattern will appear, especially in the fine resolution images with tiny details. In fact, the moiré pattern was visible in all the monitors. The Sony CPD E100 showed more moiré pattern than the rest, but you could easily reduce this by 80-90 per cent using the moiré cancellation feature present in the OSD.

To evaluate the monitor's capability of displaying fine detail properly, the focus matrix test was run. A total of five tests were run and we observed the coarse, fine and diagonal resolution matrix pattern.


The 15-inch Compaq MV540 comes with good-quality detachable speakers

HP 55, ViewSonic E50 and Microtek Flatvision38FI, performed well in this test. The coarse pattern was displayed perfectly, the diagonal lines also did not show much jaggedness and the fine pattern emerged clearly too. However, all the monitors showed slight haziness in the corners, making the pattern lose its sharpness in the corners.

In the 19-inch category, the monitor that did well in these tests was the Acer P911, which displayed the pattern clearly, with no moiré pattern. But even this monitor showed a coloured tinge in the pattern, which made the lines appear off-white.

In the 21-inch category, the LG StudioWorks 221U was a shade better than the Viewsonic G810 but again both the monitors showed a slightly hazy image in the corner.

Screen pixel resolution: Your video card renders the image that you see on the monitor in conjunction with the display driver. The pixels that make up the image are arranged horizontally and vertically. This arrangement makes it almost impossible to generate the perfect curve or inclined line because the neighbouring pixel has to be lighted up. If this neigh-